

01

RELIGIOUS EXPERIENCE: NATURE AND OBJECT

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

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MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

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CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

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UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

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ANSWER LINE: □ Fact: A 2025 Frontiers in Neuroscience review described neuroscience of religion as the study of correlations between brain functions and religious practices, beliefs and experiences, while emphasizing methodological and definitional limitations. □□ Inference: Neural mediation does not by itself prove either veridicality or illusion.

02

RELIGIOUS EXPERIENCE: NATURE AND OBJECT: CORE DISTINCTIONS

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Is religious experience veridical (of a real object) or merely subjective/psychological? □□ For veridicality: Principle of Credulity (Swinburne) — if it seems to one that X is present, probably X is, absent defeaters; the noetic quality; convergence of mystics.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

[!IMPORTANT] Mystical experience is a mode of religious experience marked, for William James, primarily by ineffability and noetic quality.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Anubhava (direct realisation): in Indian thought the highest religious experience is immediate, intuitive realisation (anubhava/aparokṣānubhūti), not mere belief — the goal of the whole spiritual path. □ Advaita (2024 PYQ) — features: □ Non-dual (nirvikalpa) experience — the collapse of subject–object duality; the realiser is Brahman ("aham brahmāsmi").

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Self-certifying (svataḥ-siddha), beyond objectifying speech (avācya; yato vāco nivartante), bliss (ānanda), beyond the categories of ordinary cognition. □□ Terminological discipline: do not call this experience anirvacanīya.

ANSWER LINE: Religious experience is an experience interpreted as disclosing or relating the subject to an ultimate, sacred or divine reality.